The 13th Degree – Royal Arch of Solomon



The apron is of crimson velvet. Upon it is embroidered a triangle emitting rays, and in the middle a letter, an archaic form of the Semitic Yod. The color denotes the zeal and devotedness of a Royal Arch Mason. The triangle is the emblem of Deity, or Infinite Wisdom, Infinite Power and Infinite Harmony; the letter represents the Tetragrammaton, the Name of God made known to Moses.

The cordon is a broad, watered purple ribbon worn from the right shoulder to the left hip from which is suspended a triangle of gold bars.

The jewel is a circular medal of gold, around which, on one side, are the following letters, words and number: R, S, R, S, T, P, S, R, I, A, J, et S, ANNO ENOCHI 2995. On the same side is an engraving of the ground with a rectangular hole in it into which two men are lowering a third by a rope. On the reverse side is a triangle emitting rays and in the middle of it the same letter as is on the apron. This medal is to be worn upon the chest, suspended by a narrow,

white watered ribbon. The letters stand for: Regnante Solomone, Rege Sapientissimo, Thesaurum Pretiosissimum Sub Ruinis Inuenerunt Adoniram, Joabert, et Satolkin...Anno Enochi 2995; or “In the reign of Solomon, wisest of kings, Adoniram, Joabert and Satolkin found under the ruins the most precious treasure.” Let the emblem on the reverse side of this jewel always remind us that the good Mason reveres and adores the Grand Architect of the Universe, and endeavors, by pursuing the path of honor and duty, to perform the part assigned him in the world well and faithfully.

DUTIES

Seek knowledge.

Be motivated by duty and honor.

LESSONS

Moral character is a habit, not formed in a moment. The great law of retribution acts in our memory as remorse and at the final judgment.

FOR REFLECTION

Are idle hours and idle words subject to the great law of retribution?

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

Enoch, Adoniram, Yehu–Aber, Satolkin, the descent into the vault, the arch, cube of agate, triangle of gold, name of Deity.

Like other degrees encountered in Scottish Rite Masonry, this degree is also known by other names: The Royal Arch of Enoch, the Royal Arch and the Royal Arch Ecossais (Scottish Royal Arch). It must be remembered that Albert Pike wrote the degrees of the Scottish Rite in the 19th century and in doing so, he selected, combined, deleted and elaborated material from the numerous and varied degrees existing at the time. The other names associated with this degree attest to both its heritage and its importance in Freemasonry.

Ecossais is a French word, usually translated “Scottish”; according to Mackey, it may also be translated as “Scottish Master” (*Ecossais Maître*). Under whatever name this particular degree may be found, it is essentially a legend accounting

for the recovery of that which was lost. The older versions recount that the True Word was engraved on a triangular plate of gold which was cast into a dry well; but the new versions relate that the True Word, also engraved on a golden plate, was deposited in a purposely prepared place to be found centuries later by three masters.

Enoch, also in a name of the degree, is an important Masonic character. He was an ancient Hebrew patriarch and predecessor of Solomon. From Genesis (5:24) we learn that his life was one of exceptional virtue; he is described "as walking with God." He is said to have lived 365 years, his earthly life ending not by death but by being bodily transported to Heaven (Genesis 5:23). We are told he received the gift of wisdom and knowledge from God and was learned in astronomy and astrology. Tradition tells us that God, seeing in Enoch a man of perfect virtue, elected to reveal to him His true name. After receiving it in a dream, Enoch's vision continued and he was conveyed vertically through nine arches into a subterranean vault which contained a triangular plate of gold upon which was written the name of God. Enoch took the dream as a sign from God and after a long journey through Canaan, or the Holy Land, he excavated nine apartments vertically into the earth each covered with an arch, the lowest hewn out of solid rock. In this apartment he placed an alabaster pedestal and mounted upon it a cube of agate into one side of which he had sunk a triangular plate of gold inscribed with the name of Deity—thus fulfilling the purpose of his vision.

Above the apartments he built a modest temple of unhewn stones with a secret passage into the apartments under a stone with a ring through it.

The Bible provides us with the reason for unhewn stones, for God decreed His altars to be such:

> *And if thou wilt make me an altar of stone, thou shalt not build it of hewn stone, for if thou lift up thy tool upon it, thou hast polluted it* (Exodus 20:25).

This passage also explains the prohibition against "the sound of axe, hammer, or any tool of iron" during the construction of King Solomon's Temple as related in Masonic tradition, which itself has a specific Biblical source (1 Kings 6:7).

The legend provided in the *Liturgy* explains that during the construction of King Solomon's Temple an administration center was needed. The site chosen for this center was unknowingly that of Enoch's original temple. It was believed that the ruins were of an ancient pagan temple. During the removal of the ruins, the secret passage was discovered. Adoniram and two of his assistants (Yehu–Aber and Satolkin) successively lowered each other into the dark vertical passage, each reaching farther than the one before him.

Finally Adoniram himself reached the ninth apartment where he discovered the treasure left there by Enoch.

The next day the three Master Architects returned and removed the cube of agate which they conveyed to King Solomon who immediately recognized the word engraved upon the golden plate in its side as the Ineffable Name of Deity. According to tradition Solomon knew the Word because he had received it from his father, David, who had received it from the prophet Samuel. Solomon created this degree, it is said, to reward the zeal and dedication of the discoverers of this great treasure.

In Hebrew, the name Enoch is *Henoch* and means: initiate, instruct, teach and dedicate. In the Koran of the Moslems, Enoch is called "Edris," derived from a word which means to read or to study with attention. In Freemasonry Enoch, therefore, has become a symbol of initiation and the acquisition of knowledge.

CEREMONY

The lodge room represents the Audience Chamber of King Solomon. It is set up, as in the 9th Degree, with silver tears on black hangings and with red and white columns at intervals. Nine Great Lights (candles) are positioned around the altar which is in the center. Another room, representing an underground vault, is strewn with fragments of rock to resemble ruins. There are no lights in this vault and it is to be profoundly dark, until the light in the luminous pedestal is revealed.

The drama requires three candidates, who represent Adoniram, Yehu–Aber and Satolkin. They must descend vertically into the deepest vault and recover the

sacred treasure. Their descent is met with many obstacles; the third attempt is successful. It should be noted the candidate in this last attempt carries a torch; his success reminds us that with the aid of light (a symbol of knowledge and wisdom) and by seeking ever deeper within ourselves, the true knowledge of Deity will be found. When all the candidates have descended into the subterranean vault, the light is extinguished. All remain in utter darkness and unknown voices speak of death and the grave.

When the pedestal is uncovered, it brilliantly lights the room and the brethren behold the Ineffable Name of Deity. This alabaster pedestal represents the light of reason, given by God to man, by which he is able to read the great book of nature and by it understand the attributes of Deity. The masters who discovered the treasure represent the types of the true Mason who seek knowledge from pure motives.

The cubical stone bearing the name of Deity is then taken to King Solomon. The candidates are rewarded for their zeal and devotedness by their advancement. Masons of the Royal Arch of Solomon pledge themselves to live virtuously and honestly. Zeal and charity, honor and duty, lead them through life.

As was done at the end of the 8th Degree, the political lessons taught in the degrees thus far are reviewed; we find:

Degrees & Political Lessons:

- 4th, 5th, 6th: *An enlightened citizenry*
- 7th: *An independent judiciary*
- 8th: *An economic order based on capital and labor*
- 9th: *An upper house of legislation*
- 10th: *A lower house of legislation*
- 11th: *Trial by jury*
- 12th: *A chief executive*
- 13th: *A constitution or fundamental law*

This degree expands the symbolic role of the three Grand Masters as representing the three Hebrew letters of which the Ineffable Name of Deity is composed: *Yod, He,* and *Vau.* Pike notes on p. 758 of *Morals and Dogma t*hat "*Yod* is *Hakemah* [Wisdom], and *He, Binah* [Understanding]; *Vau* is *Tephareth* [Beauty], and the last *He, Malkuth* [Dominion]" (emphasis, translation in square brackets added). If this is not entirely clear it is only because a greater understanding is reserved for higher degrees.

LECTURE

This lecture provides foundational material for subsequent degrees and indirectly discusses the important duties of this degree: to seek knowledge and to be motivated by honor and duty. Pike also presents the idea that there is a "religion of life and of society ... and of truth and right action in the world" (p. 212). He gives a definition of religion much broader than is usually assigned: the development of the nature given us by God and so "the pursuits and occupations of this life, its activity, care, and ingenuity ... tend to promote [God's] great design in making the world" (p. 211). Pike's use of the word "religion" in the following quotes is in this context and should not be confused with the use of the word now more generally recognized. Pike believed that to seek knowledge when motivated by honor and duty is the practice of religion. There is also religion in toil, in professional work, in society, in Masonry, in the family and in nature. God is the great Creator of man and the world. He created man's nature. If everything that a man does is done rightfully and faithfully, he will be a good man and will naturally help to work out his own salvation. Should a man fail to act religiously in his life, the great law of retribution will act to answer for his future.

This lecture also teaches the progressive nature of man's awareness of God and His attributes. Originally feared, now He is to be seen as a God of love. Originally seen as a physical entity, now He is transcendent:

... the conceptions of God formed by individuals varied according to their intellectual and spiritual capacities; poor and imperfect, and investing God with the commonest and coarest [sic] attributes of humanity, among the ignorant and coarse; pure and lofty among the virtuous and richly gifted. These conceptions gradually improved and became purified and ennobled, as the nation advanced in civilization—being lowest in the historical books, amended in the prophetic writings, and reaching their highest elevation among the poets (p. 206).

To Practice Honor and Duty is a Religion:

...there is a religion of toil. It is not all drudgery,.... It has a meaning and an intent. A living heart pours life–blood into the toiling arm; and warm affections inspire and mingle with man's labors. They are the home affections. Labor toils a–field... ; but home is its center; and thither it ever goes with its earnings, with the means of support and comfort for others; offerings sacred to the thought of every true man, as a sacrifice at a golden shrine (p. 212).

There is also a religion of society. In business, there is much more than sale, exchange, price, payment; for there is the sacred faith of man in man (p. 213).

When friends meet, and hands are warmly pressed, and the eye kindles and the countenance is suffused with gladness, there is a religion between their hearts; and each loves and worships the True and Good that is in the other (p. 213).

The same splendor of kindly liking, and affectionate regard, shines like the soft overarching sky, over all the world; over all places where men meet, and walk or toil together; ....There is not a worn stone upon the sidewalks, but has been the altar of such offerings of mutual kindness; ... (p. 213).

There is an element of good in all men's lawful pursuits .... The ground on which they tread is holy ground. There is a natural religion of life, answering, with however many a broken tone, to the religion of nature (p. 214).

Retribution:

The great law of Retribution is, that all coming experience is to be affected by every present feeling; every future moment of being must answer for every present moment; one moment, sacrificed to vice, or lost to improvement, is forever sacrificed and lost; ... (p. 216).

That which we are doing, good or evil, grave or gay, that which we do today and shall do tomorrow; each thought, each feeling, each action, each event; every passing hour, every breathing moment; all are contributing to form the character, according to which we are to be judged. ... every idle word and idle hour will give answer in the judgment (p. 216).

God has formed thy nature, thus to answer to the future. His law can never be abrogated, nor His justice eluded; and forever and ever it will be true, that "Whatsoever a man soweth, that also he shall reap" (p. 217).